capital was Rs 10 lakh—40,000 shares at Rs 25 each. How much of this had been subscribed? And how much remained to be taken?

As of 1 April 1908, 27,000 odd shares had been subscribed to with certain other shares not being counted due to disputing claims, the nature of the disputes not being clear. While this amounted to about Rs 8 lakh of subscribed nominal capital, only about Rs 62,500 had been paid-up. Further, 'with the advent of the new directors about three lakhs of capital have been collected'.[63] While these are figures given by K.R. Guruswami Aiyar (during his audience with the governor), *The Hindu* quoted a figure of Rs 7 lakh as paid-up capital.[64] *The Hindu* was probably indulging in some mild, but understandable, exaggeration. A month later, in May 1908, 75 per cent of shares—i.e. 30,000 shares—had been taken up, *The Hindu* claimed.[65]

The annual report gives more exact figures. As of 31 March, 32,759 of the authorized 40,000 shares had been taken. Of these, only 24,109 shares had been fully paid up with another 8,650 shares realizing only Rs 30,386. The shortfall on unpaid shares was Rs 3,66,889.[66] Not much progress had been made after 31 March. Sometime after VOC's arrest, 'The business of canvassing shares had to be temporarily suspended though the persistent and successful working of the Company was bringing bills for payment.'[67]

It was in light of the above—that there were only less than 7,000 new shares to be issued—that the authorized capital was doubled in the general body meeting of 3 July. Even though the registrar of companies gives the official date of increase of the authorized capital as 18 December 1908,[68] the SSNCo had begun to immediately issue new shares following the shareholders' resolution.

Nationalist partisans welcomed the increase in the authorized capital. Thus, Subramania Bharati reassured himself that his 'concern about the fate of the company after Sri V.O. Chidambaram Pillai was unfairly sentenced to transportation' had been allayed and that VOC would be overjoyed at the progress made by the company.[69]